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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1994-1995

Coverage Date: 1950-2003

**Place Coverage**

Sinafala village, central-eastern Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): The Illusive Market

During my first visits to villages in the Gwembe, I was surprised that there appeared to be no system of markets where local people met to sell their produce and supplies, and to buy things not available in their own area. In other rural areas of countries or regions where I had worked or visited, including Haiti, Mexico, other parts of the Caribbean and Central America, and also the Middle East, a market often rotated village locations throughout a rural district on a weekly basis—each day the market taking place in a different village. It seemed an efficient way for people to exchange goods not available to them in their own village and to earn a small income from their own produce. These markets also facilitated socializing and business communication. I was astonished to learn that the Gwembe had no such system of rotating markets. How did people get food that grew in other places? How did they get town-produced cooking supplies? How did they maintain communication with other regions? The absence of a formal market system led me initially to the impression that Gwembe people were indeed quite limited in economic activity and isolated from the rest of the country.

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Attending my first village funeral exploded that impression. During my first month living in Sinafala village, Drivas suggested that we visit a funeral—on its second of five days— to find some of the old women I still needed to meet. Older women are fundamental to any village funeral, and because funerals last five days, most old women are found there rather than at their homes or fields during those days. It seemed like a reasonable suggestion to me, so off we went to the neighboring village, about an hour's walk from my homestead.

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As we arrived at the homestead hosting the funeral (for one of the senior men in that village), I had my first realization that funerals were something to which I would need to pay attention. Here, clearly, was a gathering of more people than I had seen in one place since visiting the central market in Lusaka. The crowds on the periphery of the funeral reminded me of crowds in a parking lot at a big-ten university football game—lots of drinking and loud conversation that at times became even belligerent. Because  82 it was my first visit to a funeral, I had no idea what to expect, and I certainly didn't expect to “walk the gauntlet” of a drunken melee, with me the prime target for derisive shouting. Over time I learned that these verbal assaults were not targeted at me personally; rather, anyone traversing any drunken event is a likely target. After a few more funeral visits, I learned how to cope, largely through learning to joke with the overzealous drinkers, but this first experience was a shock and made me dream of the peace and quiet of anonymity in the United States.

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Human Relations Area Files

*755 Prospect Street*

*New Haven, CT 06511*

General Inquiries:  [hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs:  [hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



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